

WHEN PERSONALIZATION DETERS DELEGATION TO ALGORITHMS: EVIDENCE FROM A PREREGISTERED EXPERIMENT*

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Abstract

Algorithmic decision aids increasingly act on users' behalf, and in many instances users can either retain control or delegate decisions to an algorithm altogether. We test whether preference-based personalization increases or decreases willingness to delegate compared with an objective optimization criterion. In a preregistered between-subjects experiment ($N = 233$), participants repeatedly chose whether to decide themselves or to delegate to an algorithm. In one treatment, the delegation option is an optimization-based algorithm selecting the option with the highest expected value. In the other treatment, it is a preference-based (personalized) algorithm selecting according to participants' previously elicited preferences. We find no evidence that preference-based personalization increases delegation relative to expected-value optimization throughout the task. Instead, personalization deters delegation in two ways. First, at first contact participants are significantly less likely to delegate to the preference-based algorithm than to the optimization-based algorithm; in subsequent decisions, delegation rates are statistically indistinguishable across algorithm types. Second, categorical non-delegation (never delegating) is substantially more prevalent under preference-based personalization (15.7%) than under objective optimization (3.4%). All in all, our results are consistent with the idea that preference-matching can raise initial hesitation and heighten concerns about personal autonomy and decision control for a subset of users, functioning as an acceptance barrier even when personalization is normatively appealing.

Keywords: AI delegation, human-AI delegation, personalization, algorithm appreciation, algorithm aversion, trust in AI, financial decision-making, preregistered experiment.

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